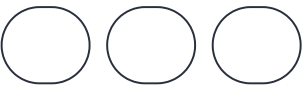


Geofinitism and the Slow Verb

An Essay on Meaning, Measurement, and the Dynamics of Words

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The Sands of Time

This essay extends the earlier trajectory developed in [*The Choice and the Attractor*](#). Previously, the noun was described as one of the deepest attractors in human thought:

a stabilising instrument through which flowing experience is converted into static things.

Here, that distinction is taken one step further. The noun is not opposed to the verb. Rather, the noun may be understood as a verb whose rate of visible change is slow relative to the observer, the culture, or the measurement window.

When we look at language from this perspective, we find grammar is not merely a classification of words: it is a measurement system. Nouns, verbs, adjectives, and abstractions are not fixed categories of meaning, but they hold different temporal behaviours within the dynamical system of language.

A noun is therefore not a fixed “thing”, it has a slow trajectory. And a verb is not merely an action, it is a trajectory whose motion remains visible within the available window of attention.

With this insight, developed here, we begin to be able to hold a different view of philosophy. Many classical philosophies are organised around stabilised nouns: Mind, Matter, Reason, Experience, Existence, Consciousness, Structure, Language.

These terms, *slow nouns*, act as attractors. They permit whole traditions to gather around them. Yet they also carry *semantic uncertainty*. Importantly, words such as “ontology” and “epistemic,” are not what they may seem. They often function less as precise instruments and more as entry tokens into established philosophical trajectories of discourse. From this perspective they may grant admissibility, but not necessarily clarity.

Vitality, Geofinitism begins elsewhere. It grounds thought in finite measurement, semantic uncertainty, and the trajectories by which meaning stabilises or fails to stabilise. Its concern is not whether a word sounds philosophically authorised, but whether it reduces uncertainty in the movement of thought.

The Distinction That Was Not Deep Enough

In the earlier essay, [*The Choice and the Attractor*](#), we described the comfort of nouns. We name a river, and by naming it we stabilise something that is never still. The water changes. The banks erode. The channel shifts. The ecological, geological, and human histories of the river continue to unfold. Yet the noun “river” works. It is not a mistake. It is an astonishing *compression*.

At first inspection, this seems to suggest a simple opposition: nouns freeze; verbs flow. But this opposition is not deep enough. A river is not a noun pretending to hide a verb. A river is a verb whose dynamics are slow enough, stable enough, and recurrent enough to permit naming. The noun does not stand outside the process. It is one way the process appears when observed through a finite window.

Language is forever changing and adapting — even nouns. The river flows quickly as water, slowly as channel, more slowly as valley, and more slowly still as a feature in cultural memory. The same “thing” is not one thing at all. It is a nested set of rates. So the distinction between noun and verb begins to dissolve.

A verb is a visible motion. A noun is a motion whose change has fallen below the immediate threshold of observation.

The noun is the slow verb.

Rate, Not Category

The classical grammatical distinction between noun and verb is *useful*. It allows sentences to be formed, taught, parsed, and translated. It is one of the great instruments of human symbolic life.

However, like all instruments, it also imposes a resolution.

Consider a child learns that “stone” is a noun and “falling” is a verb. This is helpful. Yet the stone is not static. It is weathering, vibrating, exchanging heat, being chemically altered, existing within gravitational and electromagnetic interactions. At a longer time scale, the stone becomes dust. At a still longer time scale, it participates in geological flow.

The “stone” the symbol has an etymology, a historical provenance of stabilisation. It is always changing and adapting to new usage. A stone in British English is also a weight, it has stabilised both as a “small rock” and a very precise “weight”. We accept this, but it is important because all words have a dynamical property.

The falling is merely the motion of “stone!” seen within a human-sized interval. A dynamical of symbolic representation seen at another rate. What we call an “object” is often a process whose rate of change of the symbol is slow relative to the organism naming it. What we call an action is often a process whose rate of change is fast enough to enter awareness as motion. This suggests a more general rule:

The apparent category of a word depends on the measurement window through which its referent is sampled.

A mountain is a noun to a human life yet it is a verb to geology. A species is a noun to a textbook yet it is a verb to evolution. A self is a noun in ordinary speech, yet it is a verb in memory, metabolism, habit, language, and relation.

A philosophy is a noun in a catalogue and a verb in the life of thought. This is part of the reason often I call Geofinitism a living philosophy. That phrase now seems more exact than first realised. Geofinitism is not only a philosophy about finite measurement. It is itself a continuing act of measurement, correction, perturbation, and re-stabilisation. It does not merely describe dynamics, it proceeds dynamically. Perhaps, then, Geofinitism is not best understood as a noun. *Perhaps Geofinitism is a itself a verb.*

The Slow Verb and the Measurement Window

To say that nouns are *slow verbs* is not merely a poetic inversion. It is a statement about measurement. Every act of understanding occurs within a finite window. We do not perceive all scales at once; we observe locally, bodily, historically, culturally, and instrumentally. A word becomes stable when the changes it conceals are smaller than the resolution of the system using it. And from this perspective, naming is a *sampling operation*.

The word “tree” gathers root exchange, photosynthesis, growth, decay, fungal relation, seasonal variation, cellular repair, and ecological interaction into a single stable symbol. It does not eliminate those processes, it hides them beneath a low-rate surface.

The noun is therefore not false. It is finite and a compression shaped by the limits of the observer.

From this perspective this explains why nouns are so powerful as they reduce the cognitive burden of the world. Without them, experience would remain too fluid to manage and communicate. To live, we must stabilise and in speaking, we must compress. To reason, we must hold something still long enough to compare it with something else. However, the concern comes when we forget that the stillness was introduced by the instrument.

The noun did not reveal the final nature of the world, it does however give the mind a handle.

The Drift of Meaning Across Time

If nouns are slow verbs, then their motion is not always visible within a single lifetime. Yet over longer intervals, the movement becomes unmistakable. Words that appear stable within one generation can shift, stretch, fracture, or invert across decades and centuries. What appears fixed is often only locally stable.

Consider the word “*awful*.” In earlier English, it meant “full of awe,” carrying a sense closer to reverence or wonder. Over time, its trajectory shifted toward the negative, until in contemporary usage it signifies something unpleasant or bad. The word did not break; it drifted. The apparent object remained, but its direction of meaning rotated.

A similar transformation can be seen in “*silly*.” Once meaning “blessed” or “innocent,” it moved through stages of “naive” and “harmless” before settling into its current sense of foolishness. At no point was there a sharp boundary at which the word ceased to be itself. Instead, its meaning flowed through intermediate states, each locally intelligible, yet collectively forming a trajectory that would be difficult to reconstruct without historical awareness.

Other words shift less in tone and more in conceptual structure. The word “*science*” in the 17th century referred broadly to organised knowledge. What we now call “science” would then have been described more precisely as *natural philosophy*. Over time, the term narrowed and stabilised around experimental method, measurement, and institutional practice. A reader approaching a 17th-century text with the modern sense of “science” risks importing assumptions that were not present in the original context.

The word “*extent*, ” used in early modern philosophy, offers a more subtle example. It did not merely refer to size or range in the modern sense, but carried connotations of spatial being — what it is for something to occupy space. In texts influenced by thinkers such as René Descartes, “extension” was not a casual descriptor but a foundational term in the attempt to define matter itself. To read such passages with a contemporary, casual sense of “extent” is to flatten a concept that was once structurally central.

Some words shift rapidly under cultural pressure. The word “*gay*, ” within the span of a few decades in the 20th century, moved from “carefree” or “light-hearted” to its now primary association with sexual identity. The earlier meaning has not entirely vanished, but it has receded to the point where its use may cause confusion or require explanation.

More recent still is the word “*cloud*. ” Once referring almost exclusively to a meteorological formation, it has, within a few decades, come to signify distributed computational infrastructure. The older meaning remains, but the newer one has become dominant in technical and professional contexts. The same symbol now operates across distinct domains, with interpretation determined by context.

Even the word “*computer*” has undergone a reversal. Originally referring to a person who performs calculations, it now refers almost exclusively to a machine. The noun has not simply shifted; its referent has been reassigned entirely.

These examples are not anomalies. They are expressions of a general condition: words move, they are dynamic and not fixed. Their trajectories are shaped by use, context, culture, technology, and institutional reinforcement. A word may appear stable within a given measurement window, yet across a longer interval, its motion becomes visible. The consequence for reading is significant. When approaching a historical text, the reader often assumes that the words carry their current meanings. This assumption is rarely examined. Yet it

introduces a systematic distortion. The reader overlays a contemporary trajectory onto an earlier one, producing a hybrid meaning that belongs fully to neither.

In this sense, interpretation is itself a measurement problem. The question is not only *what does the word mean*, but *what did the word do at the time of its use*. What trajectory did it participate in? What alternatives surrounded it? What distinctions did it carry that may now have dissolved?

To read carefully, then, is not merely to parse sentences, but to attend to the temporal behaviour of words. It is to recognise that the noun on the page is not a fixed object transported intact through history. It is a slowed process, observed at a different point along its path. The word you encounter is not the word that was written. It is the current position of a trajectory that began elsewhere and will continue beyond the present.

A Brief History of the Noun-Attractor

Much of Western philosophy may be read as a history of stabilised nouns. Plato gave philosophical force to *Forms*. Aristotle gave us *substance, category, cause, essence*. Descartes sharpened the distinction between mind and body. Locke and Hume organised inquiry around experience, impression, idea. Kant placed conditions, categories, understanding, and reason at the centre of his system. Hegel moved toward process, but even there Spirit, History, and Dialectic became named structures around which interpretation could gather.

Later traditions continued this pattern:

- Materialism stabilised around matter.
- Idealism around mind or idea.
- Empiricism around experience.
- Rationalism around reason.
- Existentialism around existence.
- Phenomenology around phenomena.
- Structuralism around structure.
- Post-structuralism around text, difference, power, discourse.

- Utilitarianism around utility.
- Pragmatism around practice, though even “practice” becomes a noun when institutionalised.

Importantly, this is not a criticism of these traditions. It is a measurement and observation about their *symbolic mechanics*. A philosophy often becomes recognisable by the noun around which it stabilises. The noun then acts as a basin for the philosophy, itself a noun. It gathers texts, arguments, schools, journals, histories, reputations, and disputes. And as it does so it tries to make the words solid and fixed. In practice, to be admitted into philosophical discourse, an idea often needs a noun.

Of course This is understandable. A noun can be cited. It can be indexed. It can become a module in academic exchange. It can sit comfortably in the sentence:

“The ontology of X...”

“The epistemic status of Y...”

“The metaphysics of Z...”

Such language signals membership. It performs familiarity with the inherited grammar. It says: I know the table at which I am sitting. But from a Geofinitist perspective, a different question arises, a question that of course in grammar needs nouns but recognises they are sources of instability:

- Does the word reduce uncertainty?
- Does it improve the trajectory of thought?
- Does it allow the reader to measure more clearly?
- Or does it merely announce that the speaker knows the password?

The Problem of High-Uncertainty Words

It seems to me, that some words carry more *semantic uncertainty* than others. This does not mean they are meaningless. However it appears their meaning varies strongly with context,

community, tradition, and expectation.

“Ontology” is one such word.

In one setting it means a theory of what “exists”. “Things” that have the state of “existence”. In another, a formal classification system. In computer science, it may mean a structured representation of *semantic entities* and relations.

In philosophy, it may carry centuries of inherited argument about being, substance, reality, existence, and categories. In casual academic writing, it sometimes functions as a grander substitute for “what this assumes is real.”

“Epistemic” is similar.

It can mean relating to knowledge, justification, belief, evidence, uncertainty, standpoint, access, privilege, limitation, warrant, or the conditions under which something is claimed to be known. It may be useful in careful hands.

But often it enters a sentence as a performance of sophistication rather than a reduction of uncertainty.

Again, the problem is not that such words must never be used. But perhaps there is a problem in that they are often used without calibration.

In Geofinitism, a word is not made valuable by its prestige. It is made valuable by its measured behaviour in a trajectory of meaning:

- A useful word reduces ambiguity.
- A dangerous word increases curvature without revealing that it has done so.
- A performative word gives the appearance of precision while displacing the burden of understanding onto the reader.

This is why plain English matters. Plain English is not anti-intellectual. It is not a retreat from depth. In practice it is often the more demanding discipline, because it denies the writer the refuge of inherited fog.

To say “what exists” and refine this statement is not always better than “ontology,” but it forces the writer to show the path and better define the dynamics of the words. Where is the motion in

meaning? My goal is to try and clarify and ground the measurement of the words and to give the words provenance. Can you feel the sense of meaning forming or are you looking for static nouns, that can never be static?

To say “how we know this” is not always better than “epistemic,” but it exposes the measurement conditions.

To say “what has been measured” is stronger still, because it asks for contact with the world. When we talk about measurement, we immediately, know it is dynamic, a snapshot, and the snapshot was a process. yet even the snapshot is a verb. The ink starts decaying due to instability.

For me, here we can see that plain english, at its best, is low-uncertainty encoding.

Semantic Uncertainty

In geofinitism *semantic uncertainty* is the uncertainty associated with the meaning of a word, phrase, or symbolic structure under finite interpretation, and *endogenous measurement*. Endogenous measurement is where we compare words with our own existing corpus of language trajectories. The documents that enable us to hold streams of symbols. You are reading this here first, you take an exogenous measurement decoding patterns of light into symbols then you compare and carry out an endogenous measurement.

Semantic Uncertainty It is not vagueness or ambiguity. It is the finite measurable instability of meaning as a word travels through different readers, contexts, traditions, and histories.

- A word with low semantic uncertainty remains relatively stable under reasonable perturbation.
- A word with high semantic uncertainty shifts strongly depending on who uses it, where it appears, and what basin of thought the reader already inhabits.

In this reading, semantic uncertainty is not a defect in language. It is part of language’s dynamical life. Poetry often uses high semantic uncertainty deliberately and myth often

depends on it. Religious language often lives within semantic uncertainty it and it seems to me philosophy has often cultivated it. Even science uses high-uncertainty words during periods of discovery, before measurement stabilises the domain.

But if the aim is careful inquiry, then high semantic uncertainty must be acknowledged, constrained, or reduced. A Geofinitist *soft* rule may therefore be proposed:

A word should not be granted admissibility merely because it has institutional provenance. It should be assessed by its contribution to reducing uncertainty within the trajectory of meaning.

This is a modest rule, but it changes the landscape of how we can speak and in the manner we speak. It asks language to behave more like an instrument.

Words as Instruments

A measuring instrument can be elegant, expensive, and historically respected, yet still be poorly calibrated for a given task. A word is no different:

- Some words are microscopes.
- Some words are fog machines.
- Some words are badges.
- Some words are doors.
- Some words are locks.

In what we may call **normal philosophy**, inherited terms often carry authority because they belong to a recognised lineage. They have passed through books, lectures, journals, and examinations. Their use signals that the writer knows the canon. However, Geofinitism asks a more severe and more generous question:

- What does the word do?
- Does it sharpen the measurement?
- Does it clarify the interaction?
- Does it let the reader reconstruct the path?

- Does it preserve the uncertainty honestly?
- Does it lower the semantic noise?

If not, then perhaps the word is not yet admissible within that trajectory. This is not censorship or simply exclusion, this is a form of measurement calibration. The purpose is not to ban *difficult* words but to prevent difficulty from being mistaken for depth and exogenous connection - that is connection to exogenous measurements where symbols are first created. This is to remind the reader that words are first read as an exogenous measurement and then they can only work and draw relationships in the endogenous symbolic framework of language.

A difficult word within the endogenous framework is justified when it performs a necessary function that simpler language cannot perform. But when a difficult word only increases semantic uncertainty while preserving the appearance of expertise, it becomes a barrier to measurement. In such a situation it becomes simply a gateway to a seat at the High Table where endogenous documents and words are curated for the sole purpose of endogenous measurement.

For me, one of the tasks of Geofinitism is to ask how do the words ultimately link to exogenous measurements: those that enable the foundational words, via gesture and sound.

Philosophy as Stabilised Flow

Returning to *normal philosophy*, we can begin see its traditions differently. A philosophy is not a fixed doctrine. It becomes a stabilised flow of language, practice, interpretation, and institutional repetition. Platonism is not merely a belief in “Forms”. It is a long-lived trajectory of language through which certain symbolic structures are granted priority over measured variation.

- ‘Empiricism’ is not merely a theory of experience. It is a trajectory that returns repeatedly to ‘sensation’, ‘observation’, and ‘evidence’ as stabilising attractors.
- ‘Materialism’ is not merely a claim about ‘matter’. It is a basin in which explanations are pulled toward ‘physical constituents’ and their ‘interactions’.
- ‘Existentialism’ is not merely a doctrine of existence. It is a trajectory in which choice, ‘anxiety’, ‘freedom’, and ‘lived finitude’ become the stabilising terms.

- ‘Phenomenology’ tries to return to experience as given, but must still name ‘phenomena’, ‘intentionality’, ‘consciousness’, and ‘lifeworld’.

Even process “philosophy”, which explicitly attempts to move beyond static substance, must name “process”. It too must convert flow into a noun in order to enter the library. This is the paradox. To become a philosophy, a living movement of thought must often become a noun; a snapshot is taken, that must slowly decay. Yet it must be named, cited, classified, taught, and defended. It must become sufficiently slow to be recognised. In this way, all philosophies are slow verbs.

- They begin as perturbations.
- They become trajectories.
- They stabilise into traditions.
- They harden into nouns.
- Then, sometimes, they become cages.

If you are still here, you may have found the quotes over the words annoying and disrupting. That is the intent. It is a reminder that the symbols, the words, do not carry the meaning - the meaning is in the relational flow. The verb and the slow noun only have meaning in relational flow, that you are giving to the words now as you measure in a dynamical interaction.

Geofinitism as a Living Philosophy

In our attempts to communicate, we necessarily take snapshots and apply compression. When we speak of a tree, I cannot go out, dig it from the ground, and present it directly. I cannot hold it up and gesture with it as an object of shared reference. Instead, I use the word “tree,” alongside other words, to construct a compressed representation i.e. a verbal, sound-oriented storyboard, a sequence of symbols that can be measured, transmitted, and interpreted. In doing so, I rely on words as instruments. However, they are tools of compression; yet we must remember that they remain tools. Quotation marks can sometimes serve as a reminder of this, not as decoration but as calibration, marking a distance between the symbol and what it attempts to stabilise.

However, something more subtle occurs. We do not merely use words — we begin to inhabit them. We situate ourselves within their flow. Meaning is not simply extracted from symbols; it is built through interaction with them. The words begin to carry more than their initial function. They gather associations, expectations, histories, and emotional weight. They expand into models. At a certain point, the transition occurs almost unnoticed: the symbol begins to feel like something external. What was an instrument begins to resemble an exogenous reality.

Geofinitism attempts to remain aware of this shift. It cannot avoid the need for a name and recognises that it is a *slow noun*. A name is useful: it gathers a trajectory, provides a handle, and allows others to point, respond, criticise, and continue the path. It also enables the selection of foundational trajectories: those words and commitments that are admissible and capable of stabilising meaning within a shared space. But the name must not become a tomb.

Geofinitism is not the claim that all questions are solved by finitude. It is the commitment to begin from finite measurement: finite language, finite symbols, finite instruments, and finite uncertainty. It asks that no word be treated as if it has escaped the conditions under which words are made and used. Its central discipline is not “belief”, but “measurement”.

We then have to ask: What has been measured? With what instrument? At what resolution? Under what uncertainty? How has the measurement been converted into symbols? What uncertainty entered during that conversion? What semantic uncertainty entered during interpretation? What has been lost by turning the verb into a noun?

These questions are not ornamental; they are the foundation. This is why Geofinitism may properly be called a living philosophy. It is living not because it is vague, unfinished, or merely personal, but because it treats meaning itself as a dynamical process under finite measurement. Its task is not to produce final nouns. Its task is to keep the trajectory measurable.

The Inadmissibility of Uncalibrated Language

It seems to me that there may be value, then, in developing rules of inadmissibility. Not rules imposed from authority, but rules of measurement discipline. For examples a term may be considered inadmissible within a Geofinitist trajectory if:

- It carries high semantic uncertainty and no local definition is provided.

- It increases the apparent sophistication of a claim without increasing its measurable clarity.
- It relies on institutional familiarity rather than functional necessity.
- It cannot be translated into lower-uncertainty language without losing most of its apparent force.
- It conceals a noun where a process should be shown.
- It converts a measurement problem into a metaphysical declaration.

Of course these are not final rules, they are starting constraints. And importantly we are at the beginning of a trajectory of thought. These *rules* may be refined, measured, challenged, and altered. They are provisional rules, to try and help stabilise our measurements within the space of language. They can be thought of rules of creating a flexible scaffold to hold the words together.

A writer, of course, may still use “ontology” but the writer has a duty of linguistic care and clarify what *they think they mean*. Similarly a writer may use “epistemic” But the writer must state the measurement conditions. And of course we can use “truth” but perhaps we should clarify whether this means correspondence, coherence, prediction, stability, agreement, usefulness, or measured persistence.

No words are or can be prohibited as they all have meaning, but that meaning needs clarifying within a wider context. We all know this, but we forget the cognitive effort takes time, the decompression of meaning takes requires extra words and we have to compress the words into a finite process and measured time.

Plain English and the Curvature of Meaning

Plain English is sometimes treated as a lower form of expression, suitable for popularisation but insufficient for serious thought. For me, this is a mistake.

Plain English can carry profound thought when it is used with care. Its strength is not that it eliminates complexity, but that it exposes the path by which complexity is reached.

A sentence filled with authorised terminology may appear precise while leaving the reader unable to reconstruct the measurement. Yet a plain sentence may appear simple while allowing the reader to follow every step. In dynamical terms, plain English can reduce unnecessary curvature in meaning space.

This does not mean flattening thought. It means removing artificial bends. It means allowing the reader's trajectory to be guided by the structure of the idea rather than by the prestige of the vocabulary. A good sentence should not merely impress but enable reconstruction with a minimum of cognitive effort.

This is especially important in a *living philosophy*. This is because if the reader cannot reconstruct the path, then the text has not transmitted a stable trajectory. In which case it may have created the feeling of depth yet be empty and fail to lock into the reader's own landscape of language. This is perhaps always the goal of writing to enable decompression and reconstruction or guide the shaping of ideas that a reader may already hold.

The Reader as Measuring System

At this point, the reader may notice that this essay is performing the act it describes. It is not asking you to accept a doctrine or some static permanent "truth", it is guiding a trajectory. You began, perhaps, with the familiar distinction between nouns and verbs.

As we have progressed perhaps the distinction was softened. Then it was displaced by rate, following which rate was linked to measurement. We then then linked measurement and then language to philosophy. We progressed along the trajectory and philosophy was linked to semantic uncertainty. Then semantic uncertainty was linked back to the words by which admissibility is performed. This is the movement of the essay, and the dynamics of language and reading.

In a sense it is a perturbation, an adjustment of your internal landscape. The words It asks you to feel where your own language stabilises. Which words seem solid? Which dissolve when examined? Which words have you inherited as tools? Which as ornaments? Which as permissions?

If the word "ontology" feels necessary, what work is it doing?

If the word “epistemic” feels precise, where is its precision measured?

If the word “truth” feels obvious, what basin is giving it that force?

These questions are not meant to destroy the words. They are meant to bring them back into motion, so their behaviour can be observed. A word that survives measurement takes hold and remains with us. A word that refuses measurement may perhaps be theatre.

The Noun, a Slow Verb Returns

We can now return to the beginning. From the perspective of dynamic motion and change, a noun is not the opposite of a verb, it is as we have seen a *slow verb*. And this highlights the relational meaning of words and how although we relentlessly hunt for a fixed and static meaning, this is impossible.

From the viewpoint of Geofinitism, philosophy is not a fixed system, it is a slow verb, as it's meaning changes across time. A word is not a container of meaning, it is dynamic and a measurement within a wider frame, of context and culture in an ever changing window of time. It is a measured perturbation in a dynamical landscape. A tradition is not a fixed body of doctrine, it is a trajectory that has persisted long enough to be mistaken for a thing.

Geofinitism, if it is to remain alive, tries to resist the temptation to become only a noun. It must accept its name while remembering that the name is a handle, not the flow. It must continue to measure its own words. It must remain alert to semantic uncertainty. It must prefer clarity over permission, function over performance, and trajectory over declaration. This does not make Geofinitism anti-philosophical.

It may make it more faithful to the living act from which philosophy first arose: the attempt to follow experience, language, and measurement carefully enough that something previously hidden becomes visible. The old philosophical question asks: What is it? The Geofinitist question asks: What is changing, at what rate, under what measurement, and with what uncertainty? The first question invites a noun. The second begins a path.

Epilogue: The Word Asked to Work

If we look through the texts of history we find that every tradition has its passwords and every discipline has its robes. And for the custodians of language every High Table has its manners, permitted gestures, inherited phrases, and subtle tests of belonging. However the measured world does not answer to passwords and measurement does not bow to robes and a trajectory is not clarified by ceremony.

Words are among our finest instruments. They let us preserve experience, transmit thought, form science, compose poetry, argue, love, remember, and build worlds. But an instrument must be calibrated. It must be tested against use and handled with great care. A word that cannot be measured in its effect on meaning should not be granted authority merely because it is old and a word that increases uncertainty should not be mistaken for wisdom. And importantly, a word that hides its provenance or path should not be allowed to claim the destination. The noun serves us well. It gives us handles, maps, laws, libraries, disciplines, and names. But now as we look deeper into language and how language works as a nonlinear dynamical system the noun must be seen more clearly.

Rather than the end of motion, a noun is motion slowed into apparent form. The river was always flowing and the stone was always changing. The philosophy was always moving. The word was always a verb and the measurement is ongoing.

Addendum: Language Under Compression

LLMs and the Dynamics of Meaning

There is a further development that must now be considered. It arises not from philosophy in the classical sense, but from a new class of instruments that have begun to participate directly in the production of language. These instruments are **Large Language Models**.

At first glance, they appear to confirm what has been argued throughout this essay. They do not store words as fixed entities. They do not retrieve meanings from a static repository. They operate through the reconstruction of trajectories: patterns of relation, recurrence, and contextual flow that has been embedded within a high-dimensional space. Their outputs are not things but sequences i.e. paths taken through a learned landscape of language. In this sense, they are verb-like systems. Yet there is a second effect, less immediately visible.

The training of such systems is an act of compression. Vast corpora of human language, themselves the accumulated trajectories of culture, are reduced into a finite set of parameters. This compression is not without consequence. It preserves some structures more strongly than others. For example, frequent patterns are reinforced. Rare trajectories are attenuated and ambiguity can be smoothed.

The very practice of engineering these systems involves the regularisation and stabilization of the responses: a forced linearisation of language. Especially as language is conceived of as relations of static vectors within the machine learning community. This community has come to their own conclusion on how meaning is held and it may be simply wrong and a poor model. The community is working in the space of philosophy and mathematics, which may be beyond the horizon of their own language.

What is learned is not the full dynamical richness of language, but a weighted reconstruction of it. This introduces a new pressure on the evolution of language itself. When such systems are used to generate text, assist writing, or mediate communication, they begin to feed back into the very corpus from which they were trained. Human language, once an open and uneven field of dynamics and change, increasingly encounters its own compressed reflection. A loop is formed:

Language produces models.

Models produce language.

Language absorbs the model's output.

The cycle continues.

Within this loop, the attractor landscape of language may begin to shift. Stable patterns deepen. Common forms become more common. Certain phrasings gain authority through repetition. Unusual trajectories may struggle to persist unless actively maintained. In the terms developed in this essay, we may say:

Systems built upon the dynamics of language may, in their outputs, favour the slow verb.

That is, they may preferentially generate trajectories that are already stable, already well-formed, already close to existing attractors. From this perspective, the result is language that is

coherent, fluent, and often useful, but also subtly constrained and perhaps less capable of being anchoring to exogenous measurement. This does not imply a loss of intelligence or capability but perhaps a redistribution of dynamical emphasis.

Consider, without care language may become on average, more regular, more predictable and more aligned with established basins. That may be what you feel is needed. However, the faster, less stable trajectories, the experimental, the idiosyncratic, the not-yet-formed, may require greater effort to sustain. They may not disappear, but they may become less likely to arise spontaneously, and just perhaps that is where new meaning can better match the exogenous measurements.

This presents both a risk and an opportunity.

| The risk is a gradual slowing of linguistic evolution.

Not a cessation, but a drift toward deeper, more stable basins at the expense of exploratory movement. A culture that increasingly speaks through its own compressed representations may begin to mistake coherence for completeness.

Opportunity lies in awareness

If language is indeed a dynamical system, which it seems to me is a good model, and if these new instruments participate in its evolution, then we are entering a new age of enlightenment. An age where it becomes possible to study, measure, and guide this process. We may begin to ask:

- What trajectories are being reinforced?
- Which are being lost?
- How does semantic uncertainty change under model mediation?
- Does the use of such systems reduce or increase the diversity of expression?
- Do they deepen existing basins or help reveal new ones?

Importantly, these are not abstract concerns as they are measurable, at least in principle. They belong not only to philosophy, but to the emerging science of language dynamics. From a Geofinitist perspective, the task remains consistent and rather than rejecting the instrument, we

measure the behaviour of language. And then rather than assuming outputs are static measurements, we examine their effect on the trajectory of meaning and language.

Then, rather than treating fluency of language as evidence of completeness, we test whether it reduces or increases semantic uncertainty. In doing so, perhaps, we may discover that these systems can both stabilise and add dynamics into a measurable system of language. LLMs may reinforce slow verbs, but they may also allow new combinations, new pathways, new couplings between distant regions of language that would rarely meet in ordinary discourse.

Our understanding of nonlinear dynamical systems tells us the outcome is not predetermined. It is on the dynamic edge of unknown unknowns and depends on how the instrument is used, how its outputs are interpreted, and how critically its influence is understood. The central recognition of this essay therefore returns, now with a new context:



Words are not things.

They are trajectories under measurement.

And now, increasingly, those trajectories are shaped not only by human interaction, but by systems trained on the compressed history of that interaction. The measurement continues: but the instruments are changing.

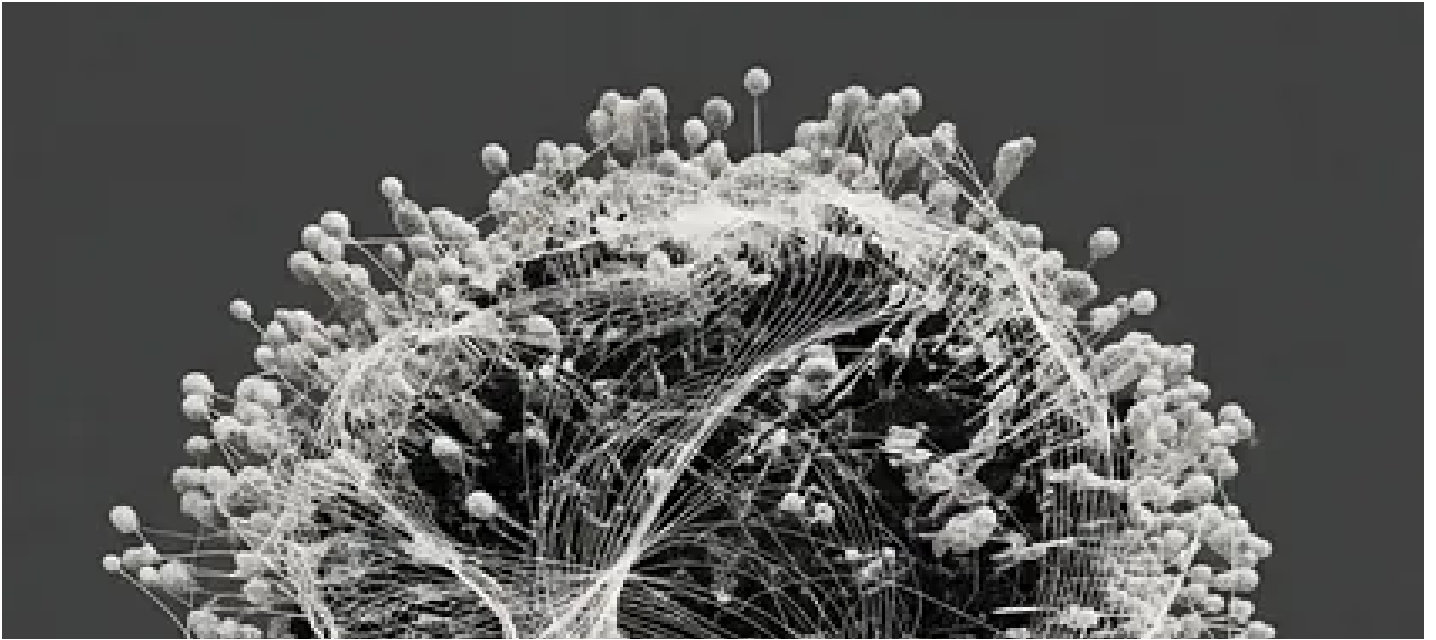
The map is a tide and the tide is a map.



Suggested References and Contextual Anchors

Geofinitism: Language as a Nonlinear Dynamical System - Attractors, Basins, and the Geometry of Understanding

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Omne quod est, finitum est; tantum per mensuram cognosci potest

Everything that exists is finite; it can only be known by measure

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